

Guidelines for Testing the Authenticity of Intuition

In seeking contact with the source of inner guidance – the “pole star” within – we are faced with the problem of determining the validity of the “inner voice.” Though true intuition, or “inner teaching” received from supraconscious levels is by definition always accurate, self-deception is common. It would be foolish and dangerous to blindly follow everything we may take for an intuition without corroboration from other sources. The adventure of evoking the psyche may bring about contact with all levels of the unconscious – from the most base and primitive to the most sublime and it is frequently difficult, particularly in the beginning, to differentiate these levels.

In general it can be said that no external criterion is absolute and that only a perfectly self-realized person has perfect discernment in attempting to evaluate the authenticity of intuition. A measure of doubt and skepticism is therefore healthy, though one must avoid the opposite extreme of allowing an excessively critical attitude to block our receptivity and paralyze all progress. It is a question of steering a middle course between the Scylla of sterile and negative skepticism and the Charybdis of naïve credulity. The fewer obstacles to clear perception of Reality there are in the form of personal hangups, inadequacies, fears, and hostilities (conscious or unconscious), the less danger there is of distortion and self-deception. As a Sufi master once put it, Satan will find a way to slip into even the tiniest crack. Hence the importance of moral purification (the first two steps of Raja Yoga) and sincerity of intention in approaching the source of inner guidance. Thus it is recommended before commencing meditation to perform ablutions as a symbolic gesture of inner intent and to attempt to raise one’s consciousness to the most elevated plane possible, invoking inspiration from the highest source you can conceive. If the intention is pure (not ego-motivated), no serious harm can result even though one’s judgment may be in error.

The following guidelines may be used in testing the validity of intuitions you receive through meditation or in other ways. As most rules have exceptions, it is wise to cross-check in as many ways as possible when you are in doubt. Above all, do not let these words of caution discourage you from trying, because it is only through practice and experience (including your mistakes) that learning comes.

- 1) In general, the voice of Truth brings a profound feeling of inner calm, certainty, and resolution, provided we are in a receptive state and willing to face without defensiveness whatever truth is revealed. There may be pain accompanying this experience, as the truth is often painful, but beneath the pain there will be a deeper feeling of “rightness” and peace. If we feel too weak to face the truth on a particular question it is better not to seek answer at this time as it will only produce conflict and guilt over our inability to take the path indicated. This is what is meant by “sincerity of intention:” that we must seek the truth wholeheartedly if we seek it and with the willingness to take whatever steps are necessary to act upon the knowledge we receive.
- 2) Be wary of any message that stimulates fear of disaster. These are usually pseudo-intuition stemming from the lower unconscious and representing neurotic fears. There are exceptions, however.
- 3) Be wary of any message that flatters you and tends to produce ego-inflation, especially of a grandiose, messianic nature. Again, the source is likely to be the lower unconscious, the cause being a compensatory attempt to deny underlying feelings of inadequacy and depression.
- 4) Reason is a valuable tool to counterbalance and check intuitive insights. It is, in any case, necessary in order to “bring down” these insights and to express them in communicable form in most cases. It is helpful to inquire as to whether the “teaching” received fits into the general body of knowledge –

both the knowledge of esoteric science as well as that of the classical esoteric traditions. A negative finding is not a certain indication that what you have received is untrue, but it can warn you to step cautiously in your interpretation and to make thorough attempts at cross-validation.

- 5) Remember that inner teaching is frequently clothed in symbols and requires a symbolic rather than a literal interpretation. A person who receives the impression that he is going to die, for example, may be approaching a moment of psychological “death” prior to an experience of rebirth and regeneration rather than the moment of actual physical death. Another famous example is the case of St. Francis who heard God tell him, “Go and restore my Church.” At first he interpreted this as referring to the crumbling church nearby and set about gathering stones to restore the old building. Only later did he realize that the message was to be interpreted symbolically as referring to the state of moral corruption in the spiritual Church.
- 6) If you are in doubt, delay action if it is not urgent, allowing time to see if your intuition is corroborated by subsequent events. This “cold storage” period frequently clears up many problems, and either points out specific pathways to follow and opportunities for action or makes it clear if your interpretation was erroneous. Tolerance of ambiguity is a characteristic of the mature person, and it may be necessary to draw on this attribute -living with uncertainty and withholding judgment until the situation becomes clear. Forcing premature closure in order to avoid the stress of such uncertainty may cause you to make the wrong decision and will, in any case, deprive you of an opportunity to exercise patience –a much underestimated virtue and an indispensable ally in the search for enlightenment.
- 7) It is sometimes helpful to consult with a wise friend or a person experienced in these matters if there is someone you can trust.
- 8) Checking by a group, as in the group meditation practiced by the Quakers or the “testing” employed in Subud, is another safeguard. If you have recourse to others in this way, they should be persons you regard as objective and impartial.
- 9) You may ask yourself what is the source of this message and how would you react in real life if you received counsel from such a source. Metaphorically speaking, does it come from a “good spirit” or a bad one? Hannibal is a historic case in point, who, having dreamt that Jupiter Capitalinus (the tutelary deity of Rome) told him to make war on Rome, acted on this advice and was defeated. A useful technique to help clarify the source is visualization or active imagination in which you look for a mental image which will represent the source of your message.
- 10) The various techniques for obtaining answers from the unconscious using mental imagery, spontaneous movement and drawing, or the pendulum may be employed to cross-check the source of an intuition or to further elucidate its meaning and implications. Divinatory methods may be employed by qualified persons well trained in their use. Even then, they should be used with discretion as there is a danger of becoming overly dependent on such methods.
- 11) First become single-minded and purify the motives in your search. Then “ask and it shall be given you: seek and ye shall find; knock and it shall be opened unto you.” For purity of heart and single-mindedness are more important than any technique to your success.